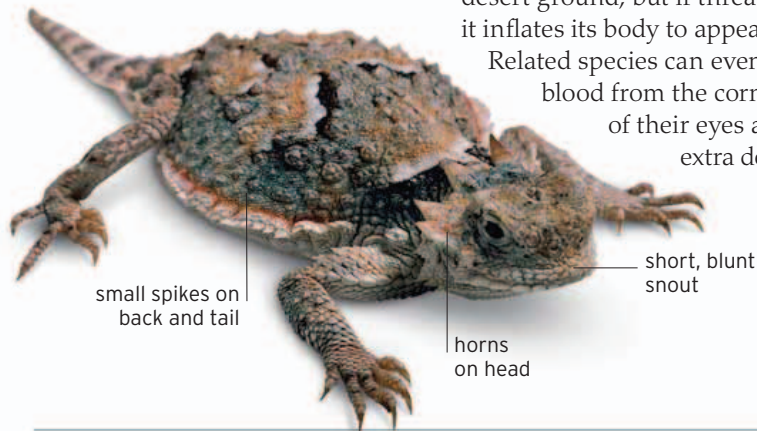


Desert horned lizard

Phrynosoma platyrhinos

- ↔ 3–5 in (8–13 cm)
- 📍 SW. US
- ⊗ Locally common



small spikes on back and tail

A thorny-skinned reptile, the desert horned lizard gets all its nourishment by eating ants. It laps up columns of these insects in quick succession using an extendible tongue. The lizard is camouflaged against the stony desert ground, but if threatened, it inflates its body to appear bigger.

Related species can even squirt blood from the corners of their eyes as an extra deterrent.

horns on head

short, blunt snout

Northern chuckwalla

Sauromalus ater

- ↔ 11–17 in (28–43 cm)
- 📍 SW. US, N.W. Mexico
- ⊗ Locally common

A large, desert-living member of the iguana family, the chuckwalla feeds mainly on vegetation—including leaves, flowers, and fruit. Males are highly territorial and defend their areas from rivals using various threat displays, including head-bobbing, push-ups, and flushing with color. Like some other related species, the chuckwalla retreats to rocky crevices when a predator comes too close, where it secures itself by inflating its body.

Rhinoceros iguana

Cyclura cornuta

- ↔ 3–4 ft (1–1.2 m)
- 📍 Caribbean
- ⊗ Vulnerable

One of the bulkiest of all iguanas, this species is confined to the dry, scrubby Caribbean habitat of Hispaniola. It is named for the raised scales on the head, which resemble horns. These “horns” are more prominent in the highly territorial males. The rhinoceros iguana is a ground-living vegetarian that is adapted to feed on the leaves of some plants that contain bitter alkaloids—toxic to many other animals.

African fat-tailed gecko

Hemitheconyx caudicinctus

- ↔ 6 in (15 cm), max 10 in (25 cm)
- 📍 W. Africa
- ⊗ Common

Like the closely related leopard gecko, this desert lizard can store fat reserves in its tail to help it survive periods when food is scarce. Its tail is fattest when it is well fed, but shrinks as the stored nutrients are metabolized. It can also shed its tail when danger threatens, temporarily distracting a predator while it escapes.

Common leopard gecko

Eublepharis macularius

- ↔ 8–10 in (20–25 cm)
- 📍 S. Asia
- ⊗ Locally common

This desert lizard belongs to a group of geckos that, unlike others, have fully working eyelids. Only adult

geckos have the leopardlike spots; juveniles have saddlelike blotches instead. This gecko preys on insects and other invertebrates, hunting mainly at dusk and dawn. Under extreme temperatures, it stays

underground, surviving by metabolizing the fat reserves built up in its tail. The common gecko's tail may be discarded in defense, but not as readily as in some other lizards.



tail contains food reserves

eye protected by movable eyelid

Common house gecko

Hemidactylus frenatus

- ↔ 5–6 in (13–15 cm)
- 📍 Tropical regions worldwide
- ⊗ Common

This small, widespread gray or brown gecko is so-called because of its habit of entering human dwellings. The undersides of its feet are covered with rows of microscopic hairs, which allow the gecko to cling to flat, vertical surfaces. It climbs walls easily and can even cling to glass. House geckos often gather near electric lamps, drawn by the insects that are attracted there.

Tokay gecko

Gekko gekko

- ↔ 7–14 in (18–36 cm)
- 📍 SE. Asia
- ⊗ Not known

One of Asia's largest geckos, this is a nocturnal lizard with a loud “tokay” call. Males are among the most vocal of geckos and call to attract females—or to defend their territories from other males. The

species has a powerful bite and will attack other lizards that stray too close. When threatened by snakes and small, nocturnal mammals, it delivers a hard bite and, if grasped, it discards its tail. The male mates with several females. The females then attach a pair of spherical, hard-shelled eggs to a vertical surface, usually protected inside a crevice.



distinctive pattern of orange spots

Northern leaf-tailed gecko

Saltuarius cornutus

- ↔ 6–9 in (15–23 cm)
- 📍 E. Australia
- ⊗ Locally common

Named for its flattened tail, the leaf-tailed gecko is a tree-dweller and has a body pattern that camouflages it against lichen- and moss-covered tree bark. Its flattened body reduces shadow as it hugs the surface of a branch or trunk. Southern-ranging forms of leaf-tailed geckos hibernate during cooler months, but this species is active throughout the year in the tropical zone.